

The Kerala Model

With a fourth international airport in the pipeline, the state is setting a trend in decongested airport growth

When the Kerala Government recently began acquiring 2,000 acres for building a fourth international airport in Kannur due to be completed by 2013, skeptics scoffed whether the state actually needed so many airports. Yet, beginning with its first greenfield airport outside the ambit of the Airports Authority of India, the state has consistently proven its critics wrong. Kerala accounts for 12 per cent of India's passenger traffic and 6 per cent of aircraft movements and is growing at roughly 20 per cent per annum. If it hasn't suffered the congestion dogging other metro behemoths or expatriate-heavy states like Punjab, it could well be due to the healthy dispersal of airports, Calicut, Cochin and Trivandrum, in the state.



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The jewel undoubtedly is the Cochin International Airport (CIAL), which is entering its 10th year. Built under public-private partnership, it is free from bureaucratic hurdles bedevilling the other airports. Today, the Rs 315-crore airport is one of the best in the country in

terms of infrastructure and services. It has also proved to be profitable even as many airports across the country are deep in the red. "Kochi is a model that other airport stakeholders would do well to emulate," says V.J. Kurian, founder MD of CIAL. **by M.G. Radhakrishnan**

THE CATALYST: India's first greenfield airport is both efficient and profit-making

tonomous air traffic control corporation as in most developed countries is being proposed by the Government as a means to speed up the induction of technology and trained manpower into air traffic services. DGCA plans to increase the capacity of air corridors by August. "We will increase peak movements by 40-50 per cent at airports, from 42-44 per hour at the Delhi airport to 60 movements per hour," says Kanu Gohain, director-general of civil aviation.

The Civil Aviation Ministry has floated a new policy which now authorises DGCA to clear the construction of new greenfield airports. AAI says it has set aside over Rs 2,000 crore for infrastructure improvement by 2010, but is overwhelmed by the onrush of passengers. "The main

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problem is that upgradation has to be carried out while the airports are operational," says V. Somasundaram, executive director, air traffic management, AAI. It is a complaint almost every airport developer has. GMR says it can work only on 10 per cent of the terminal area in Delhi without overly inconveniencing passengers. "We are doubling almost all passenger amenities, check-in counters and introducing in-line baggage screening to cut delays," says Arun Arora, spokesperson, DIAL. The grand new Terminal 3, due for completion ahead of the 2010 Commonwealth Games, will soak in 60 million passengers or over twice the current traffic.

Aviation watchers say nothing short of an aggressive upgradation of infrastructure, radars and communication systems will help airports handle the increasing passenger load. Like the GMR slogan, Indian airports may eventually become the best in the world tomorrow. But it is the wait for them that is proving to be killing.

with Malini Bhupta, M.G. Radhakrishnan, Ramesh Vinayak, Amarnath K. Menon, Stephen David and Lakshmi Subramanian

SATURATION POINT OF EXISTING AIRPORTS

Due to saturation at airports like Bangalore, passengers often take international flights out of other cities like Mumbai

"Planners failed to anticipate the rapid growth in traffic."

ATUL JALAN
MD, MANITHAN SYSTEMS